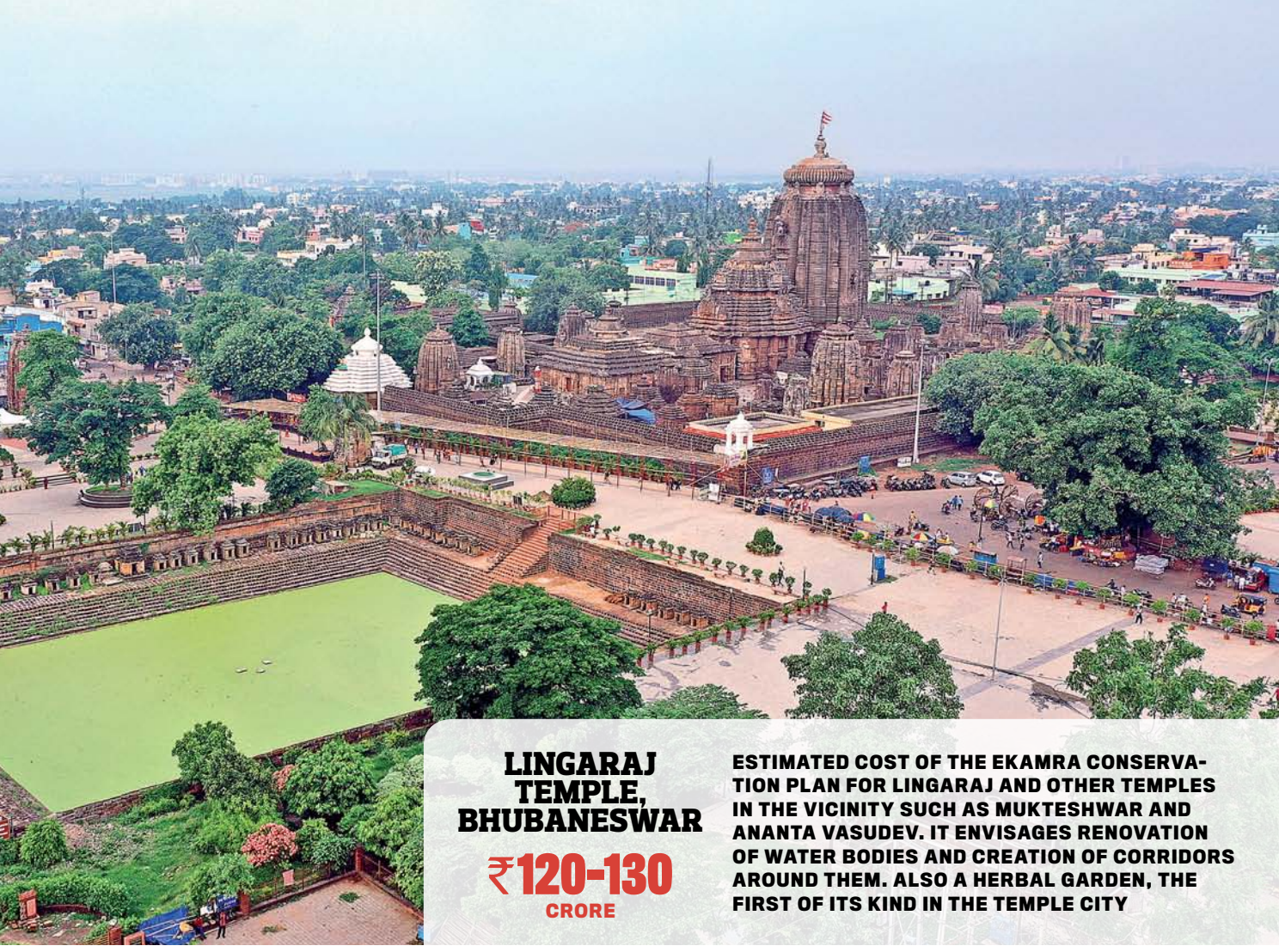


LINGARAJ TEMPLE, BHUBANESWAR

₹120-130 CRORE

ESTIMATED COST OF THE EKAMRA CONSERVATION PLAN FOR LINGARAJ AND OTHER TEMPLES IN THE VICINITY SUCH AS MUKTESHWAR AND ANANTA VASUDEV. IT ENVISAGES RENOVATION OF WATER BODIES AND CREATION OF CORRIDORS AROUND THEM. ALSO A HERBAL GARDEN, THE FIRST OF ITS KIND IN THE TEMPLE CITY

According to BJD MP Amar Patnaik, the project was taken up with "the sole objective of increasing the convenience of pilgrims, particularly the old, disabled, women and children". And yet someone reportedly close to Aparajita Sarangi, the BJP MP from Bhubaneswar, filed a PIL against the project. Senior administrative officials accuse Sarangi of playing politics to take the wind out of the BJD's sails. "If Naveen takes all the credit for the beautification of temples, the BJP's agenda to stir Hindu sentiments in Odisha will become redundant. The ASI's delaying tactics seem to be part of a political script," says an official. Moreover, the allegation that the ASI was kept in the dark doesn't hold as the DG, ASI, who is also an ex officio member of the NMA, had visited the sites and met the CM, assuring full cooperation. All political parties were on board during a presentation in the Vidhan Sabha on February 27, 2021, and their representatives present at the inauguration ceremony along with ASI and NMA officials.

While work at the Jagannath Temple is going slow, renovation around the Lingaraj Temple has come to a halt, with the ASI claiming that remains of ancient structures were found during digging. "There is a temple at nearly every spot around Lingaraj," says Ramachandra Ratha, a priest. "The 9th-century Gourishankar Temple is in the middle of a busy thoroughfare. The 14th-century Teertheswara Temple is in a private courtyard. The Bhabani Shankar Temple from the same period was hidden behind unauthorised shops and other buildings. By clearing encroachments, the government has restored the beauty and dignity of the temples."

The sudden suspension of work has led to a new problem. With all shops and vendors removed, pilgrims have no place to sit and no provision for drinking water. "The stay on renovation has multiplied their inconvenience," says Kabu Mishra, a priest at Bhabani Shankar Temple. Accusing ASI of playing "temple politics", Amar Patnaik says: "NMA is the overarching body for monuments and everything around them, while ASI has to safeguard archaeological remains. Sadly, ASI is going beyond its remit and jeopardising pilgrim-related development works." However, Arun Malik, ASI's superintending archaeologist, Bhubaneswar circle, denies he was obstructing approvals. "Nothing is pending from my end. You have to ask [the Delhi authorities about] the delay," he says. "But now that the Supreme Court has given the go-ahead, everybody has to abide by it." ■